Unit – 4 Professional Etiquette

4.1 Concept of Social Manners, Morals and Etiquette

Good manners and proper etiquette matter more than ever in our society, whether it is in academic classrooms, social settings, or in public places. Good manners and social etiquette are more than just polite habits—they are fundamental life skills that shape how children interact with the world. Teaching basic manners at an early age helps children build positive relationships, show respect for others, and develop confidence in social situations. By providing consistent guidance and modeling courteous behavior, parents lay the foundation for lifelong success and empathy. This article explores simple, practical ways to teach children basic manners and social etiquette.

4.2 Etiquette for Small Talks

Small Talk is usually an introduction to a more serious business conversation later or it supplements the main activity or conversation you are pursuing. It is a part of ice breaking process, setting up the environment to be more conducive to serious business conversation.

The reasons behind the need of small talk in the office:

- Small talk is a nice lead – in for a more serious business conversation.
- It helps the participants to settle down.
- Right at the outset, small talk conveys the message, 'I am a nice and friendly person. You will be happy to deal with me' and therefore, helps the rest of the transaction to go smoothly even if there are technical or business problems along the way.
- You create a friendly, fun atmosphere to work in and transact business.
- You can 'scope out' people and identify the friendly ones.
- You can network with people and strangers and build relationships.
- It helps you mingle socially. It breaks the ice with strangers.
- It makes it easy to navigate through the rough spots, lightens up the tense situations and can ease the 'customer – vendor' gap.
- Is a measure of hospitality displayed by the host.

Characteristics of Small Talk

- Highly cultural dependent
- Should be bright, fun positive and light.
- An exercise in building chemistry among the participants.
- One can vary from topic to topic and number of participants can also vary.
- It can be about a variety of topic as long as they are non – intrusive and neutral.
- It should lighten up the atmosphere around, so that it facilitates actual business discussion.

- Content should be genuine.
- It should provide enough opening and comfort level for strangers to join in.
- As its fragmented, it can end any time without anything going amiss.
- Small talk is fuelled by the desire to get build rapport rather than to know the personal details of the other person.
- It has a staccato like structure.

How to be effective in small talk?

- Requires slightly extroverted personality, smiling face and a bit of aggressive demeanor, which comes with practice.
- Through small talk poise, confidence and smartness is expressed.
- Effective communication skills, body language, listening skills etc.
- Consider the interest levels of the topic.
- Topics should be current and engrossing to people.
- Know the pulse of audience, what excites them, its audience is informal.
- Requires to be aware an avid follower of current events and to know the major happenings.
- Stick to some standard topics until expertise is gained.
- In the beginning stick to smaller groups.
- If a good topic can't come up then 'you' be the topic and narrate one of your anecdotes and try to come up as a genuine and amusing people.
- Take the initiative
- Avoid probing questions
- Include everyone
- If there seems to be any potential controversial topic or potential conflicts or embarrassments then nip them in the bud or joke out of them.
- The purpose of an effective small talker is to engage everyone and conduct the conversation, thus don't become the main speaker and overwhelm the audience.
- It's expected to be good at small talk as well as serious technical discussions thus one should be able to switch back and forth between these two modes.
- Even if one isn't a great talker, one can participate is small talk effectively by being a good and active listener. Just when to laugh, respond, comment and interject.

4.3 Workplace Etiquette

When it comes to working in an office or other professional setting, etiquette matters. How you present yourself and interact with those around you—whether your coworkers, supervisors, or direct reports—speaks to who you are as a person and as a member of the team and can directly influence the trajectory of your career.

Be Punctual and Manage Time

Don't "Reply to all" to an email chain

Communicate Professionally

Ask questions if necessary and don't reply to your seniors back to back.

Don't have personal talk at your desk

Respect for Colleagues

Don't be suspicious to every one

Don't laugh at others mistake

Professional Appearance and Conduct

Adopt teamwork and Collaboration

4.4 Mobile Etiquette

Sitting anywhere in the world we can share information, make requests, discuss business matters and be in touch with our family, friends and colleagues over the phone.

In a telephonic conversation, the two parties cannot see each other's facial expression and other aspects of body language. This makes it all the more important for them to incorporate the correct tone and articulation in their voices, so that the purpose of the phone call can be achieved successfully. Some etiquette that you need to follow are…

1. Use polite expression such as 'How can I help you?' / 'May I help you?'
2. If you are the receiver, identify your name and name of organization.
3. Be clear and precise.
4. Listen to the caller patiently.
5. Before you call up anybody, think what and how to discuss.
6. Reduce the background noise if any.
7. Pick up the phone as early as possible.
8. If you do not return the missed call, tell the reason.
9. If you are the caller, ask the other person that "is it a good time to talk?"
10. Always keep a pen and note pad while taking calls.
11. Thank the caller before ending the call.

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12. Do not shout.
13. Do not use slang language.
14. Do not interrupt the caller.
15. Do not eat or drink while speaking on the phone.
16. Do not talk to others around you, while speaking on the phone.
17. Do not call the client after office hours.
18. Do not assume about any information.

4.5 Internet & Social Media Etiquette

Social media has changed the way we communicate both as an institution and as individuals. At official place when we use official internet of our organization we have to be more conscious about surfing. Sites like stock market are not allowed at work place but most of employee breaks this rule. Social media etiquette refers to the accepted norms, guidelines, and practices that govern appropriate behaviour and conduct on social media platforms. It involves understanding and following the unwritten rules and expectations of online communication to promote positive interactions and maintain a respectful and productive online environment.

Here are some key aspects of social media etiquette:

1. Respectful and Constructive Communication

Interacting with others in a respectful and polite manner, even when expressing differing opinions. Avoiding personal attacks, offensive language, or cyberbullying.

2. Privacy and Data Protection

Respecting the privacy of others by not sharing personal information without permission and being mindful of data security and privacy settings.

3. Responsible Content Sharing

Verifying the accuracy of information before sharing, avoiding the spread of misinformation or fake news, and crediting original sources when sharing content.

4. Proper Attribution and Copyright

Giving credit to creators when sharing their content and respecting copyright laws by not plagiarizing or using copyrighted material without permission.

5. Respecting Platform Rules and Guidelines

Familiarizing yourself with and adhering to the specific rules and guidelines set by each social media platform to ensure responsible and lawful use.

4.6 Etiquette for Foreign Business Trip

Foreign business trips are becoming increasingly common part of regular work requirement. Young professional are sent on a foreign business trips by their organization. Such trips are becoming very crucial to the success of the organization and the personal success of the professional thus it's required to study about the etiquettes for such trips to get higher mileage for it.

General guidelines about the foreign trips:

When you are on a company business trip, your individual identity is overridden by your organization's identity and you will have to represent it through the trip, also you will be representing the face of modern Indian professionalism thus, you will have to exercise tremendous restraint and good judgment in case of any ordeals during the trip.

- You shouldn't let your organization down either by criticize it or deride it.
- If at all you are suppose to make commitments during the trip to other parties, make such commitments which are within your level of authority.
- Never criticize your country.
- Don't hesitate to keep up your religious and personal identity, but it shouldn't divert the purpose of your visit.
- If you have food habits that require special needs (e.g., vegan) make sure you use the internet and other resources to find appropriate places nearby.
- Remember in US, travelling by car is the default option, if you ask any address to someone, no one will tell you regarding how to get the public transport to that place, thus if you aren't driving you would have to think seriously about reaching your destination as cabs are quite expensive. You may have to ask someone for a *'ride'* and not *'lift'* as we say in India or you would have to research well on modes of public transport there before you go.

One need to know the objective of the trip and plan properly and thus here are some points to be kept in mind.

Know Your Objective

It is important to know why you are going there, your mission, whether there's a strategic plan behind it, if yes learn about it or whether it is a part of a bigger plan, part of a grand scheme. Thus, there should be a sense of purpose, an excitement in the air, about doing an important job for your organization. Some possible missions are as under:

- A technical mission like installing a software product on your customer site.
- A knowledge transfer by which you are going to get trained by your foreign counterparts.
- A 'scoping out' trip to do due diligence.
- The final step in winning an off – shoring deal.

Some unstated objectives are:

- Rapport building
- Building networks

Prepare Well

- Make sure you have assembled and organized all data required for your trip both in the hard copy and in soft copy, as necessary.

- Make sure you have written down the contact numbers of essential people and places in your organizer/cell phone as well as in your diary.
- Build redundancy and save your important material in two or three places. Make contingency plans for such possibilities as lost luggage and have someone in your home base who can feed you computer files, data and other things in a pinch.
- Make sure your desktop in your home base is clean and properly organized.
- Make sure you have all your travel documents in order. Also, look at the security notices and warnings that airlines and governments issue every now and then that places seemingly impossible restrictions on hand baggage.
- Make sure you carry power adapters for the several different power outlets of the parts of the world you are visiting. It is a good idea to have a universal adapter.
- If you are a part of a delegation, you will have to make sure that you have covered all the materials among all of you and that nothing has slipped through the cracks.
- Finally, make sure you bring with you plenty of your latest business cards and a diary or journal with a couple of good pens.

During your Trip

- Be aware of the local laws and practices
- Respect privacy
- Interface with your foreign team
- Pay attention to networking
- Help conduct perfect presentations and meetings
- Be in constant touch with your home base and your boss in India
- It is okay to talk in your native language amongst yourselves
- A business trip is not a junket
- Be frugal about spending money

After the Trip

- Send a courteous 'Thank You' mail to your counterparts.
- Brief your boss about the trip.
- Write an apt trip report and circulate it among relevant people.
- Follow through on the action items you promised and take it to completion.
- File the expense report

Summary

- Make sure you understand the role you need to play in the trip.
- Plan well for your trip, get all data and documents organized before you leave.
- Carry everything you need for your work – business cards, relevant documents, etc.
- Have a back up in your office in India so that he can access your data, if needed.
- Respect the local laws and the privacy of your hosts.

- Build rapport and your networks in addition to accomplishing your specific tasks.
- Keep your home office informed.
- Be very cost conscious.
- Debrief the appropriate people after returns and formally close out the issues with your foreign counterparts.
- And don't forget to thank your foreign hosts for their hospitality.

4.7 Etiquette for the Visit of Foreign Counterpart

One needs to be a perfect host when your foreign counterparts and other foreign stakeholders visit your location. As a perfect host, one should not only exceed the expectations of your foreign visitors had about the trip, but also set the stage for a sustained, strong and special business relationship with them. It will involve knowledge transfer, project kick-off, review meetings, planning meetings etc.

Preparing for the visit:

- Know who the visitors are;
- Preparing the infrastructure for a visit;
- Preparations for the Business side of the visit

Know the visitors:

You need to find out some things about them to help you prepare for their stay:

- Is this their first time in India?
- Did they get any not-so-pleasant experiences in India in their last visit?
- Do they have any special personal needs like medical, religious, food, mobility needs?
- Do they have any preferences for place of stay?
- Do they have time and do they like to take some weekend time off for sightseeing or shopping?
- Do any of your team members know anything more about any of the specific visitors? In particular, is there any tough nut among the visitors that you need to put special focus on?

Finding answers to these questions would put you in better position to make the visitors more comfortable and put them in a better frame of mind for the actual business meeting that is indeed the purpose of their visit.

Preparing the Infrastructure for a visit:

First impressions are the best impressions but India has some negative baggage thus, there are some tips to make sure your infrastructure preparations are going in the right directions:

- Make sure you have made appropriate arrangements for pick up and drop off, especially in case your visitors are coming to India for the first time and ensure that you have some English speaking driver available to take them around.
- In case the visitors want to do any shopping or sightseeing, it would be great if the driver is an expert on the local shops and tourist spots. It is also okay for one of the local team members who knows the local conditions, to accompany them, should that be desired by the visitors and be acceptable to the team members.
- Make sure that you have back up power supply to keep the meeting running uninterrupted and that all your audio and video equipment and other infrastructure are humming along fine.
- If the agenda calls for conference calls or video conference, then make sure that the right equipment is available. A conference room with video conference facility may need to be booked in advance.
- It is also a good idea to prepare for the availability of drinks like coffee and tea and not to assume that there is a one size fits all coffee or tea.
- What is called 'cool drinks' in India is often called 'soft drinks' in other places and some visitors may want caffeine free drinks thus stack the refrigerator with various combinations.
- The visitors may want 'on-demand', instead of the ceremonial, scheduled coffee breaks and thus, have a pot brewing all the time and easy access to soft drinks.
- Make sure every one of your staff who is going to attend the meeting has his/her business card with their proper job titles, ready.
- Finally, be sure your toilets are neatly maintained and easily accessible.

The Actual Visit

The foreign delegation troops into your office and it is time to execute.

Start of the meeting:

- Whether you are a main presenter or among support staff attending the meeting, formal wear is necessary.
- Handshake is required – grab the other person's hand firmly, shake it vigorously two or three times and then let go immediately afterwards.

- Introduce yourself while shaking hands, avoid saying 'Myself …' instead say, ' I am …'
- Remember the name, however unfamiliar it might sound, if you don't get it for the first time, ask it again, but remember it.
- The protocol was men didn't shake a woman's hand, unless the woman offered it in the first place. But due to the emergence of concept of gender equality, this protocol isn't followed completely.
- While shaking hands, handover your business card and get theirs, with standard designation.
- While sitting around, more important persons should take the vantage positions.
- Your foreign counterpart is scrutinizing every move of yours in the first ten minutes thus, put your best foot forward and beware of your body language as well.

The meetings proper

- Time management is crucial and it's important to cover all the points mentioned on the agenda, failing that (may be due to a prolonged discussion on any one topic by the counterpart), plan an extra meeting.
- Try and understand the question of your visitor and answer it aptly and if unaware about the details, then get it from someone and give the details.
- Stick to hierarchy and protocol during the meeting for presentation or giving in the details.
- Even if you are privy to the information still let your superior reveal it and only chip in when required.
- If you don't understand the accent of your visitors, ask them to repeat it and likewise, if they don't get yours, repeat.
- If a member of the delegation asks about some information outside the meeting hall, if you aren't sure if it can be passed on then confirm it with your boss.
- Don't do private favors to members of the visiting team. Similarly, don't give them the 'insider's view' about your company, however much you are prodded and made to talk.
- These days business meetings are informal thus, its fine go in and out without disturbing the proceedings so one can receive important phone calls but it's necessary to keep the phones on silent mode.
- It is perfectly fine have the side bar conversation with the supporting staff in the local language.
- Coffee breaks are an opportunity for small talks.
- Elaborate business lunches of golden days are replaced with working lunch these days thus choose a simple, convenient and functional meal for example sandwiches rather

than greasy, oily, messy meals. One can also choose meals which can be eaten with spoons and forks.

- Learn to eat and talk, though it might require some practice.
- There's one common pattern which is found across the organization that during the coffee breaks and lunch, Indian group hangs out together and chit chat, so visitor's feel lost thus let the social butterfly of your side lead the charge to start a conversation with them.
- Lunch is a good time to explain people's functionality and the role in the project. And it is also proper to allow fifteen minutes settling time after lunch during which the guests can check their emails or phone.
- Every once in a while, clients might try to unleash their God given right to act difficult by finding faults, express utter disgust, dissatisfaction with the work etc. Don't take it personally and become sensitive, also, react on the moment. Instead if any clarity needs to be given from your end then, approach your boss later.

Getting to conclusions and agreements:

- As the meeting goes for long, fatigue and boredom seeps in leading to sloppiness and wandering attention.
- It is necessary to stay alert and on the top of situation.
- Lack of stamina may end you up with a bad deal.
- Even though all kinds of psychological games may be played by both the sides, a clear consensus should emerge.
- The last part of the meeting might be negotiations, renegotiations, discussion, status assessments etc.
- Negotiations on sensitive matters are best left people having corporate power.
- Later on let your legal team pores over the matter and then you finish signing it.